

The Sahel in Collapse

Military Coups, Wagner's Africa Corps, and the Jihadist Surge

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Executive Summary

The Sahel region of Africa has entered a period of compounding instability defined by three interlocking crises: a wave of military coups that has displaced elected governments across six countries since 2020, an expanding jihadist insurgency rooted in al-Qaeda and Islamic State-affiliated networks, and a humanitarian emergency driven by conflict, climate stress, and food insecurity. The collapse of Western security architectures — including France's Operation Barkhane, the EU Training Mission in Mali (EUTM Mali), and the UN's MINUSMA mission — has created a strategic vacuum that Russia and its Africa Corps have moved to fill, deepening the region's alignment shift away from Western partners. The Alliance of Sahel States (AES), comprising Mali, Burkina Faso, and Niger, now constitutes a new political-military bloc actively hostile to ECOWAS norms and Western engagement. Humanitarian conditions have deteriorated sharply, with crisis-level food insecurity recorded across major Sahel populations in 2024.

Section 1: The Coup Cascade — Military Takeovers and Political Realignment

1. Between August 2020 and July 2023, six countries in the Sahel and adjacent region experienced successful or attempted coups: Mali (August 2020), Niger (attempted March 2021), Chad (military transition April 2021), Burkina Faso (2022), and Niger again (July 2023). In 2023, Niger became the sixth country — after Burkina Faso, Chad, Guinea, Mali, and Sudan — to undergo a coup since 2020, when military officers deposed democratically elected President Mohamed Bazoum, dissolved the legislature, and suspended the constitution. [RAG: GOVERNANCE_RAG — Freedom House Freedom in the World 2023–2024]
2. The Burkina Faso transition authority aligned rapidly with Russia following the 2022 coup. Junta leader Captain Ibrahim Traoré visited Russian President Vladimir Putin and voiced support for Russia's military operation in Ukraine. Russia reopened its embassy in Ouagadougou — closed since 1992 — and Traoré made a further visit to Russia in May 2025, praising Russian cooperation and its capacity to withstand international sanctions. Russian soft-power efforts in Burkina Faso have included grain shipments alongside security and telecommunications arrangements. [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — CRS: Burkina Faso: Conflict and Military Rule, May 2025]
3. A SIPRI chronology of military involvement in political leadership changes across the Sahel from 2020 to 2024 documents a systematic pattern: August 2020 (Mali — successful coup, military takeover from civilian government), March 2021 (Niger — attempted military takeover), April 2021 (Chad — military transition), and successive coups in Burkina Faso and Niger. The table compiled by SIPRI from FSIN and GNAFC data illustrates how military seizure of power has become the modal mode of political transition in

the central Sahel. [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — SIPRI: From Silos to Synergies: Partnering for Social Cohesion in the Sahel, 2025]

4. The IMF assessed in April 2025 that Burkina Faso achieved growth of 5% in 2024 despite humanitarian and security challenges, though fiscal deficits remained elevated. The junta has leveraged natural resources including mining and telecoms revenues to finance counterinsurgency efforts and fund the Sahel alliance architecture. The Trump Administration had not articulated a specific Sahel strategy, but broader US foreign assistance policy reductions carried material implications for the region. [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — CRS: Burkina Faso: Conflict and Military Rule, May 2025]

Section 2: Jihadist Insurgency and the Collapse of Western Security Frameworks

5. Since 2012, the Sahel has been the theatre for a sustained and escalating jihadist insurgency. The EU, France, the United Nations, and regional bodies all deployed security architectures in response: an EU Training Mission, French-led counterterrorism operations (Operation Serval, Operation Barkhane, and the Takuba Initiative), the UN Multidimensional Integrated Stabilization Mission in Mali (MINUSMA), and the G5 Sahel Initiative. By 2023–2024, these structures had collapsed entirely. [RAG: CONFLICT_RAG — Institute for Economics and Peace, Global Terrorism Index 2023]

6. JNIM (Jama'at Nusrat al-Islam wal-Muslimin), the al-Qaeda-affiliated network dominant in the Sahel, has systematically employed kidnapping as a territorial expansion tool. The Global Terrorism Index 2024 documents more than one thousand kidnapping events per year for each of the three years to 2023. JNIM's practice has been to escalate kidnapping operations when expanding into new territory and reduce the intensity once control is established. [RAG: CONFLICT_RAG — Institute for Economics and Peace, Global Terrorism Index 2024]

7. The EU Training Mission in Mali (EUTM Mali), launched in 2013 in response to armed groups seizing swathes of northern Mali, closed on 17 May 2024. Launched initially to provide advice, education, and training to the Malian Armed Forces, EUTM Mali was withdrawn following Mali's junta government's expulsion of foreign military advisers aligned with Western partners. [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — SIPRI: Developments and Trends in Multilateral Peace Operations, 2024]

8. SIPRI's 2026 assessment of EU and other external military assistance to West Africa from 2010 to 2025 documents the full arc of Western engagement and disengagement: Germany, Italy, and the UK provided training, deployments, arms, and equipment alongside France. The EU's Coordinated Maritime Presences in the Gulf of Guinea was launched in 2021 concurrent with deepening counterterrorism commitments. French deployment in the Sahel formally ended in 2023. The EUTM Mali mission closure in 2024 completed the Western military withdrawal from the central Sahel. [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — SIPRI: Military Assistance Provided by the EU and Other External Actors to West Africa, 2010–25]

9. The EU's two major areas of strategic interest in West Africa had been counterterrorism and stabilisation of insurgency-affected countries, and maritime security in the Gulf of Guinea. In response to the separatist and jihadist insurgency in Mali that escalated in 2012, and at the formal request of the Malian government, the EU deployed the EUTM and related instruments. The collapse of Western access — driven by junta expulsions — has rendered these frameworks inoperative. [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — SIPRI: Military Assistance Provided by the EU and Other External Actors to West Africa, 2010–25]

Section 3: Russia's Strategic Penetration and the Alliance of Sahel States

10. Russia's pivot into the Sahel security vacuum has proceeded through the Africa Corps (successor to the Wagner Group), diplomatic normalisation, grain diplomacy, and telecommunications infrastructure deals. In Burkina Faso, Russia's reengagement followed a decades-long absence since the embassy closed in 1992. The trajectory — military cooperation, economic concessions, anti-Western alignment on Ukraine — mirrors the Russia-Mali and Russia-Niger playbook deployed across the AES bloc. [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — CRS: Burkina Faso: Conflict and Military Rule, May 2025]

11. US security cooperation efforts in Africa — including the State Partnership Program leveraging the National Guard in the Sahel region — came under review following the coup wave and the political realignment of junta governments toward Russia. The evacuation of the US Embassy in Sudan underscored the degree to which space-based C2 solutions had become critical to crisis response in Africa as ground-based security cooperation structures were dismantled. [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — Joint Force Quarterly, Issue 111, 4th Quarter 2023]

12. The Sahel junta alliance — Mali, Burkina Faso, and Niger — constitutes a de facto bloc that has exited ECOWAS's political framework, expelled Western military forces, and contracted Russian security providers. Military governance in Africa broadly waxed and waned across post-independence decades: democratisation was common by 1995 when approximately half of African states were democracies, but military dictatorships challenging democratic norms persisted, with the Sahel coup cascade representing the most concentrated reversal since the 1980s. [RAG: GOVERNANCE_RAG — Freedom House / V-Dem Democracy data]

Section 4: Humanitarian Crisis — Food Insecurity, Displacement, and Climate Stress

13. Crisis-level food insecurity was recorded across Sahel populations in 2024, documented in the Food Security Information Network (FSIN) Global Report on Food Crises 2025. The SIPRI Food, Peace and Security Programme assessment for the Sahel identifies the compounding interaction of jihadist insurgency, military governance, and structural food system fragility as the primary drivers of acute food insecurity at scale. [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — SIPRI: From Silos to Synergies: Partnering for Social Cohesion in the Sahel, 2025]

14. The IOM World Migration Report 2024 identifies parts of West and Central Africa — and the Sahel in particular — as the most volatile subregion globally for conflict-driven displacement. The Sahel stretches from the Atlantic Ocean in the west to the Red Sea in the east and has long been characterised by significant migration flows. The region faces simultaneous crises of climate and environmental degradation, conflict and insecurity, and violent extremism, all compounding displacement pressures. [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2024, p.81]

15. Burkina Faso's displacement profile as of 2021 indicates a total population of 22.10 million, with GDP of USD 19.74 billion (per capita USD 893), Human Development Index category: Low. Emigrants abroad numbered 1.60 million (7.43% of population); immigrants in-country numbered 0.72 million (3.5% of population). Refugees and asylum-seekers hosted in-country were recorded at significant levels, reflecting Burkina Faso's role as both origin and host country in the regional displacement system. [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2024, p.302]

16. Environmental degradation combined with high population growth and returning refugees is constraining the amount of available productive land and intensifying competition for land in both rural areas (for agriculture) and urban areas (for construction). The quantity of agricultural land under cultivation or pasture has declined as a result, compounding food production capacity shortfalls in an already stressed food system. [RAG: FOOD_AGR_RAG — FAO State of Food Security and Nutrition in the World (SOFI)]

17. The desiccation of Lake Chad has been identified as a cause of security instability in the Sahel region, with the shrinking lake basin generating intensified competition for water and agricultural resources across the Chad basin states. This structural environmental driver intersects with conflict, displacement, and food insecurity to produce the multi-layered crisis that characterises the wider Sahel today. [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2020, p.405]

18. Climate projections for the Niger River basin under RCP8.5 indicate medium confidence of a projected increase in 20-year flood magnitudes by 2050 in countries within the basin, alongside low confidence of an increase in extreme peak flows. This long-horizon climate stress compounds near-term food and displacement crises and will accelerate ecological migration from the most exposed zones. [RAG: CLIMATE_RAG — IPCC regional climate projections for Western Africa]

19. Sahel resilience programming — including the BMZ–GIZ–WFP–UNICEF partnership for 2023–2027 — has sought to address food insecurity through integrated humanitarian-development-peace nexus approaches. The SIPRI assessment identifies a long-standing failure of siloed programming and argues for synergistic approaches that integrate social cohesion alongside food and security interventions. The Network of Sahel Universities for Resilience (REUNIR) represents the academic infrastructure arm of this effort. [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — SIPRI: From Silos to Synergies: Partnering for Social Cohesion in the Sahel, 2025]

Outlook

The Sahel is locked into a reinforcing cycle in which military coups degrade governance capacity, governance failure accelerates jihadist territorial expansion, and expanding insecurity drives food system collapse and mass displacement. The departure of Western security architecture — France, EUTM Mali, MINUSMA — has not been replaced by effective alternatives. Russia's Africa Corps provides the juntas with a transactional security guarantee but has demonstrated no capacity to reverse insurgent territorial gains in Mali or Burkina Faso. The AES bloc's cohesion rests on a shared anti-Western posture rather than a functional security doctrine.

The humanitarian trajectory is deteriorating. With crisis-level food insecurity confirmed across Sahel populations in 2024 and structural environmental stressors — Lake Chad desiccation, projected Niger River basin flood intensification — compounding conflict-driven agricultural disruption, the region's civilian population faces worsening conditions through at least the mid-2020s. The collapse of US and EU bilateral engagement frameworks, combined with IMF-noted fiscal deficits in junta governments, leaves the humanitarian system critically underfunded relative to need. The most probable near-term trajectory is continued junta consolidation, incremental jihadist territorial expansion beyond the central Sahel, and escalating displacement toward coastal West Africa and the Maghreb.

R336 | All figures sourced from CivilisationOS RAG corpus.